elites of colonised societies began asserting themselves. From seeking political autonomy as dominions within colonising empires, they gradually progressed to demanding freedom as sovereign and independent ‘nation-states’ that could write their own destinies just as colonising nations could. The aspiration of the colonised to be sovereign nation-states on European lines has been attributed to European coloniality[1] owing to close to two centuries of unbroken colonialism. Scholars are of the view that coloniality was entrenched in colonised societies through the politico-legal infrastructure of European colonisers as well as the education system introduced by them, which shaped the thinking of the native elites. In fact, the early introduction of colonial education systems in colonised societies and the replacement of indigenous epistemologies and their structures ensured that coloniality informed their present, shaped their ideas of the future and, critically, coloured their vision of the past.[2] Depending on the inherent vitality and resilience of colonised cultures, the extent of internalisation of coloniality in the consciousness of dominated societies became truly evident when even their quests for political independence from the coloniser were based on the very framework introduced by him.

Most colonised societies did not realise that their entire worldview had changed, for they could not see beyond political independence and aspired for freedom to govern themselves, albeit using the same values and institutions they had ‘inherited’ from the European coloniser. In other words, owing to coloniality, the vision of independence of most native elites was limited to the politico-economic sphere, namely decolonisation, but did not include decolonialisation because they accepted the European worldview on the all-important cultural front as well.[3] Therefore, all that the colonialised native elites sought by way of ‘independence’ was the agency to be able to write their own futures but using the ideas, rules, tools and institutions of the erstwhile coloniser, which were designed for top-down imposition on a conquered and subjugated people in order to ‘civilise’ them.[4]

While coloniality is a fairly plausible explanation for the quest of nation-statehood of colonised societies, a more pragmatic way of looking at it could be that the global presence of European colonising empires, and therefore, the global spread of colonial politico-economic ideas and institutions, may have made it inconceivable and infeasible for colonised societies to revert to their precolonial forms of political and social